PRELUDE XVI

THIS is a slow movement (8 in the bar) in which the demisemiquavers must show no such jerkiness or pettiness as would bring an artificial manner into the broad violin-like *cantabile*.

At bar 7 the bass takes up the theme, freely inverting it and (according to a reading adopted here from one of the best MSS.) initiating at the end of bar 8 a new figure which is taken up by the upper parts. At the fourth crotchet of bar 12 the two upper parts complete each other melodically, though each retains its own meaning.

In bars 14-15 mark well the dominant pedal outlined by the bass, especially at the point where (in the middle of bar 15) it is relinquished with a downward step.

The shakes, which should swell out like the *messa di voca* of the best *bel canto*, end, without turn, on the last semiquaver of the bar. The final shake may end, as suggested by Kroll, with a turn, thus: 

FUGUE XVI

THE Countersubject is neatly derived from the Subject by inverting its two figures, beginning with the second and joining it imperceptibly with the first. It thus has a character of its own, and yet in the cumulative effect of the Stretti it contributes a part indistinguishable from that of an ordinary inversion of the Subject. But on no account should the contrast between Subject and Countersubject be destroyed by breaking the Countersubject up into its component figures.

In cases where the use of these figures as accessories overlaps with the complete themes, the accessories should be given in a lighter tone; see especially bar 15, where the anticipation (in the very same notes) of the second figure of the Subject is charming if it is only faintly heard, but disturbing if prominent. In no other Fugue is it more important that both Subject and Countersubject should stand out apart from all fragmentary allusions.

Of the two real Stretti, the first is that in the upper twelfth between bass and alto (with Countersubject in treble) in bars 17-18. Being designed in double counterpoint in the twelfth it becomes (in bars 28-29) a Stretto in the lower octave between the other two parts, soprano and tenor, to which the bass adds an entry of the first figure in the lowest octave. (This repercussion in the tonic at three octaves is a favourite means of climax with Bach.) Meanwhile, the alto crosses over the soprano with part of the Countersubject. Bring out the bass, but keep the alto quiet so that the soprano may easily penetrate with its Subject, especially in its unexpected skip from A to D (instead of the final B♭), whereby it regains its position above the alto in bar 29.

Note the indication of short massed chords (a sign of climax) in the five-part final two bars.

The Episodes (bars 8-11, 18½-20, 24½-28) are all derived from the second figure, and are not differentiated. They should be taken quietly.

The *tempo* is a slow four, a little too flowing for eight in the bar. A sonorous *legato* is best throughout, with special fullness where the bass is deep.

Donald Francis Tovey: The Well-Tempered Clavier, Book I
Associated Board, 1924. Printed pp. 105.
BWV 861. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
Full source scan